

VICTORIA AND ALBERT MUSEUM

A LASTING LEGACY
The tomb of Humayun, photographed around 1857 by Felice Beato; (below) a miniature painting of Humayun by Payag, c. 1650

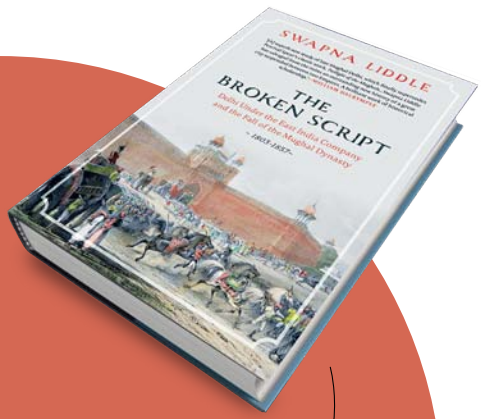


INDIA PICTURE

History, they say, has not been kind to Humayun. The second Mughal king lost his fledgling kingdom to the Afghan, Sher Shah, in a decisive battle at Chausa—a place better known for its late-ripening and rather sweet mangoes; on the run, while crossing the Ganga in spate, he fell off his horse, only to be rescued and taken to the opposite bank by one Nizam, a water carrier, on an inflated hide (*mashak*), normally used to carry water. Ever grateful to the *bhishti*, Humayun put the lowly Nizam on his throne for half a day, a turning of the world upside down, an event illustrated in the majestic official account of the reign of his son Akbar. Building alliances and fighting battles against his brothers, Humayun sought refuge in the court of the Iranian king, Shah Tahmasp. Defeating the Afghans in a rematch, he returned to Delhi in 1555 and reclaimed the throne of Dinpanah, or Purana Qila as it is called today. He began to raise new buildings, among which was the fetching octagonal-domed pavilion, an observatory and his book-lined library. Negotiating its killer high steps (Koch provides a full-page view of the daunting stairs), Humayun stumbled to his death while rushing to catch the evening prayers.

In this sumptuous book, studded with fine paintings and incisive commentary, Ebba Koch, the foremost historian of medieval Indian architecture, has unpacked Humayun's complex personality that historians plying their usual trade have failed to come to terms with. No other medieval ruler, Koch tells us, organised his court according to planetary cosmology; designed court costumes and rank-obliterating court games; conceived astrological tents and carpets; and constructed moveable palaces, floating bazaars and gardens, boat palaces and moveable bridges. Basing herself on contemporary descriptions, Koch brings these to life by generating computerised three-dimensional drawings. More intrigu-

EBBA KOCH SUGGESTS THAT **HUMAYUN'S TOMB** IS A POSTHUMOUS REALISATION OF HIS IDEAS AND DREAMS



THE BROKEN SCRIPT
by Swapna Liddle
SPEAKING TIGER
₹899; 456 pages

BOOKS

THE END OF EMPIRE

Swapna Liddle paints a portrait of Delhi at the cusp of the East India Company's takeover

When empires reach their end, their brand of civilisation often clashes with the one now assuming guard. *The Broken Script* draws an exhaustive account of Delhi from 1803 to shortly after the Sepoy Mutiny of 1857, under the de facto rule of the British East India Company, responding to the power shifts under way in this tumultuous period. The Mughal empire had devolved from ruling large swathes of the country to being a mere delegator of power, while the colonial power continued to shape-shift, growing in political and military might.

Swapna Liddle's meticulous work, which takes us through the rules of Akbar II to Bahadur Shah 'Zafar', dispels the myth that the Mughal emperors did little as the East India Company eroded the last vestiges of their empire. It informs us of how the royals employed various devices such as symbols and ceremonies, and